

in and chat with an entire group. Instant Messaging is a relatively new idea wherein a sense of personalisation was created. IRC, however, was for groups of people with a common interest. There are several IRC servers running. But with the advent of e-groups (for example, Yahoo! Groups) the idea of IRC seems implemented in a more organised fashion.

Some IRC clients that can be used on Linux are ChatZilla (by Mozilla), Xchat, BitchX, etc. You can find a more detailed listing with reviews and download links on <http://www.ircreviews.org/clients/platforms-unix.html>

Some Linux distros have a bundled GUI IRC client that you can use. If you are new to IRC, don't just jump into any room! First find out if the group matches your interest, then watch it for a couple of days and then introduce yourself before shooting away text.

7.5.4 P2P

Peer to Peer, often called P2P applications, are software through which users can share personal files with other users on the Internet. The only requirement is that both users must have the same P2P software and, of course, an Internet connection. There are several P2P clients out there, but none can claim the success of Napster before it was pulled down. Today, one of the most popular P2P networks is BitTorrent.

BitTorrent works through user groups who track the progress of a file being shared. Rules can be set to ensure that every member shares some amount of data. There are several software that can be used to download and shares files through BitTorrent. The official site of BitTorrent is www.bittorrent.com, from where you can download the BitTorrent client. It is different from other P2P clients in the way users can look for content. You cannot simply browse another user's computer for files to share. A user who wishes to share his files has to make what is called a torrent file that contains details about the file. This torrent file has to be shared with the people who want to download the file(s), either by mail